

BEFORE

Early human populations were nomadic, moving around in search of food, as it became available.

LIFE ON THE MOVE

DIGGING TOOL Up to about 10,000 years ago, life revolved around the constant search for food. New areas were gradually colonized as groups of people sought to **exploit new sources of food**.

LIFESTYLE OF THE HUNTER

The way of life of the hunter-gatherers was highly successful and adaptable.

TEMPORARY SETTLEMENTS

Hunter-gatherer sites, such as hunting camps, were seasonal and impermanent. Examples we know about include Star Carr in Britain and Dolní Vestonice in Central Europe **◀ 30–31**. **People on the move had fewer possessions**, so they could remain mobile. This lack of material objects means that our evidence of this lifestyle is meager.

BIRTH OF AGRICULTURE

The switch to farming **◀ 36–37** began about 10,000 years ago. Tools, such as the **digging tool**, shown left, developed as part of this transition. The **first plow** was used at about the same time.

Village Life

The cultivation of domesticated crops and livestock brought with it permanent settlements and new ways of life, including the first settled communities and the beginning of religion and worship.

The earliest farming villages were small huddles of mud-brick houses, nestled together and separated by narrow spaces. At Abu Hureyra, Syria (see pp.36–37), several hundred farmers lived in close proximity to their fields and each other. In another early settlement, 'Ain Ghazal, in modern Jordan, herds of goats were kept and wild animals were hunted. 'Ain Ghazal seems to have become a victim of its own success as its population grew and the land became overexploited, causing people to leave in search of more fertile lands.

Growing settlements

Jericho, in the Jordan Valley, was one of the first villages to grow successfully, over the period 9600–7000 BCE. By 8000 BCE it had become a small walled town, whose inhabitants lived in

beehive-shaped houses with stone foundations and plastered floors, many of which had private courtyards and ovens. Another highly successful, long-lived, and large settlement was Çatalhöyük in Turkey (see pp.36–37), which thrived from 7000 BCE and was inhabited for over 1,000 years. Its population lived in rectangular houses, built very close together, which were entered through the roof. The houses were whitewashed and painted with red geometric patterns. One reason for the site's success may have been its trade in the highly-prized black volcanic glass, obsidian, used to make cutting tools.

Surviving day to day

Cereal grains were the staple diet in all early farming communities across southwest Asia. Apart from bread or gruel (commonly oatmeal boiled in

water or milk), people in the first permanent village settlements lived on the meat and produce from their domesticated herds and supplemented their diet with wild game and wild plant foods.

One of the key features of these settlements, which marks them out from early hunter-gatherer sites, is the existence of storage facilities for food. This indicates that communities were planning for the season ahead and storing grain over the winter. These early farmers would have lived from harvest to harvest, and the danger of starvation was always present. In some ways, they had been better off as hunter-gatherers, as gathering food is less labor-intensive than producing it. They would have enjoyed more leisure time and less risk of disease brought about by overcrowding in villages (see pp.52–53). However, the benefits of farming—the ability to support more people from a smaller area—allowed populations to grow and society as we know it today to flourish.

Specialization

People now lived in crowded villages, with the same neighbors for generations. Men were probably responsible for herding animals, perhaps some of the work in the fields, and hunting, while women prepared food, and were responsible for foraging and food storage. Within such communities specific roles developed, as not everyone was required to find food. At the same time, some people became part-time specialists such as shamans (see pp.32–33) and spirit mediums, canoe builders, and potters. A network of family members would have helped each other in times of crop failure.

Burial rites

With more permanent settlements came new beliefs. Fertility of the soil was associated with new life. Ancestors were associated with the fertility of the land and were worshipped. Some of the dead at Jericho were decapitated and buried beneath the floors of their houses. Their relatives then modeled the revered ancestor's features in clay on the skulls and buried them in pits. At 'Ain Ghazal, collections of clay figurines were also buried in a deliberate fashion. Although the purpose of these ritualized objects is unknown, their existence indicates that people may have been practicing an early form of religion (see pp.40–41).

The rise of community life

In the first villages, people would have lived in close communities like this modern-day Tuareg village in Mali, Africa, on an island in the Niger River. Domesticated animals including goats and sheep would have been corralled and kept in areas between the houses.

INVENTION

POTTERY

Fired clay vessels are a feature of all early farming cultures around the world. Bowls were used for cooking and eating; large jars and round-bottomed pots held liquids or stored grain. Most early vessels were made by joining clay coils, or by shaping a pot from a clay lump.

Pots, such as this particularly sophisticated example, first appeared among the Jomon people of Japan before 10,000 BCE, and in Mali, West Africa, at about the same time. Most pottery was for strictly utilitarian purposes, but skilled potters also made fine-walled, elaborately decorated vessels for grave goods or ceremonial purposes.

